

Peyronie's Disease

WARWIKI

Patient Information · Scar tissue that bends the penis, and what helps

In Peyronie's disease, a patch of scar tissue (a **plaque**) forms in the wall of the penis. It can make the erect penis **curve, narrow, dent or shorten**, and erections may hurt. It can make sex hard. It is common, it is **not cancer**, and there are treatments. The right one depends on the stage.

About This Condition

Peyronie's usually has two phases:

- **Active phase.** The curve is changing and erections may hurt. This often lasts about 12–18 months.
- **Stable phase.** The curve has not changed for at least 3 months, and pain has usually gone.

Your team will ask how things have changed over time, because the choice of treatment depends on the phase.

What Usually Happens

- **Pain** goes away on its own in most men, about 6 to 9 in 10.
- **The curve** rarely goes away on its own. It improves in only about 1 in 10 men. In the rest it stays the same or gets worse.
- Many men also notice some **shortening** or weaker erections over the years.

What Causes It

It is thought to start with small injuries from bending during sex, which heal with too much scar. It is more common with age, with diabetes, and in men who have **Dupuytren's contracture** (a similar scar cord in the hand).

Learn the Terms

Peyronie's disease

Scar tissue in the penis that causes a curve or other change in shape.

Plaque

The patch of scar tissue that causes the bend.

Active or stable

Whether the curve is still changing or has settled.

Traction therapy

A device that gently stretches the penis each day.

Collagenase (Xiaflex)

A medicine injected into the plaque to help break it down.

Plication

Surgery that places stitches on the longer side to straighten the penis.

Grafting

Surgery that cuts the plaque and covers the gap with a patch.

Do I need surgery? Not right away. Surgery is only for a curve that is stable and makes sex hard. If you can still have sex comfortably, you may not need any treatment.

How It Is Checked

- Questions about the curve, pain and erections, and an exam to feel the plaque
- Photos of your erection that you take at home
- Before a procedure, an injection in the office to cause an erection so the curve can be measured, sometimes with an ultrasound

How It Is Treated

- 1 Active phase.** Pain medicine such as ibuprofen if erections hurt. A **traction device** may help; modern ones are worn about 30–90 minutes a day.
- 2 Collagenase (Xiaflex) injections.** The only medicine approved by the FDA for Peyronie's. It is for a stable curve of about 30 to 90 degrees. No sex for at least 4 weeks after the second shot of each round.
- 3 Surgery (stable phase).** **Plication** is simpler but shortens the penis by about 1 cm on average. **Grafting** is for severe curves, but it carries a higher risk of new erection problems.
- 4 Penile implant** if you also have erection problems. It treats both at once.

Vitamin E, fish oil and similar pills have not been shown to help.

Call the office that is treating you if you have:

- A curve that is getting worse or stops you from having sex
- Painful erections, or new erection problems
- Low mood or worry about your sex life

Go to an emergency department if:

- After a collagenase shot, you hear a pop and the penis quickly swells or bruises
- You have thoughts of harming yourself
- You cannot reach the office and are worried

Three Things to Remember

- 1.** Peyronie's is scar tissue that bends the penis. It is common and not cancer.
- 2.** Pain usually settles, but the curve rarely goes away on its own.
- 3.** Treatment depends on the phase. Surgery waits until the curve is stable.